

Group Material

Statements for *Democracy Poll/Demokratische Erhebung*, 1990

The publication of the *Versuche* [experiments] marks a point in time when certain projects are no longer meant to provide individual experiences as “works” but are instead directed toward the use or transformation of particular institutes and institutions as “experiments”... The second Versuch, *Stories of Mr. Keuner*, represents an attempt to make gestures quotable.

Bertolt Brecht, *Versuche 1–3* (Gustav Kiepenheuer Verlag, 1930), 1 (trans. Emmelines)

Those who do not understand must first feel that they are understood. Those who are meant to listen must first feel that they are heard.

Bertolt Brecht, “Lehren” [Lessons], *Geschichten vom Herrn Keuner, Zürcher Fassung* (Suhrkamp Verlag, 2004), 72 (trans. Emmelines)

For *Democracy Poll/Demokratische Erhebung*, Group Material crafted statements from 120 interviews conducted by the group and its collaborators in North America and Germany. Transcripts were translated as needed and edited in English to produce individual texts, which the group attributed to real and invented identities: “each representing a particular position or voice; each placed in direct juxtaposition to other voices; each adding to a collective representation of a political pattern.” Three sets were developed, with longer statements displayed across 16 advertising spaces at four U-Bahn stations (following the group’s characteristic “Da Zi Bao” [chinesische Wandzeitung] poster technique, here in a much-reduced graphic style and in sentence case, to accommodate German readers) and in a 50,000-run insert in the newspaper *Der Tagesspiegel*; shorter texts ran between advertisements on the electronic billboard of Wandzeitung [Wall Newspaper] AVNET in Berlin’s City West business district. The statements below are those provided by Group Material to the commissioning institution, nGbK, for translation into German.

U-Bahn Posters

Wittenbergplatz (department store)

I think West Germans have a very capitalist mindset, but I also think there are signs that consumerism is being curbed a bit, which is just starting to emerge in East Germany. I suppose it’s going to get worse, and I hope it doesn’t come to the point where we end up raising our children in a totally consumerist Germany.

Student, West Berlin

Americans get so far removed from the political process that they stop caring. They get involved with their BMWs and don’t take anything else into consideration. It is ultimately all economically based. I listen to my father who is very conservative. I listen to him talk. He is providing for a family of four and you can understand his reasoning. They are providing for you and everything but at the same time it is weird. It scares me to think about having a family and what kind of world I’m going to be bringing a family into. And if I’m going to have to be one of those people closing my eyes to get by.

Student, New York

Kreuzberg upper level

I would like to be patriotic without having a fatherland. I could do without a fatherland and without what's going on here just now. Yes, on the one hand I think that just now it is in a way becoming possible to deal with our past and also with fascism. For me it has become possible again and more interesting. I hear about this in a lot of conversations I have. But on the other hand, in the media and in other entertainment a lot of things get swept under the carpet, as if we had to be making a fresh start. That's not so.

Psychologist, West Berlin

The ego of most West Germans is based on their economic situation and the fact that probably in no other country in the world do simple folk live so well. The idea just occurs to me that the safest way of ensuring that never again a war will be started on German soil is to make sure that the Germans always live a little better than their neighbors, thus they do not seek to assert their own worth in military exploits.

Taxi driver, Kassel

Patriotic feelings were more predominant in November than now, and it's been replaced by the feeling of coming together, to do something good, not in the sense of patriotism above everything, but that Germany becomes a united fatherland, a peaceful starting point on a European scale, dealing with the past, unification of Europe, with a powerful effect on the East—that's the basis of the leadership role of West Germany... When we come together economically, culturally and socially, we will be an example for the Eastern countries, for the unification of Europe.

Retired pilot, East Berlin

Germany is powerful, somehow aggressive, and is the economic leader in the whole world and is geared to wanting more, which is carried out in an aggressive way, if need be, and I figure things will turn out that way. Conservatism is on the rise because people are stupid and they can only see as far as their own nose. They see that a bunch of people propagated Marxism and Leninism and they mix up the teachings with the teachers. But that isn't the case because those people were right-wing themselves, they were fascists. But they don't comprehend that. And that's why people are now thinking that they're "done with all that red communism. Now we want to have a little nationalism and a little conservatism." Pretty stupid.

Welfare recipient, West Berlin

Kreuzberg lower level

Before it used to be just America versus the Soviet Union, but now there are a lot more forces coming into being which are going to diminish the power of the States slightly with the united Germany and united Europe. It's not just east and west anymore, it is center as well. It seems that the only way you can work is if you are a huge power, and why is that? Why can't people cope as small countries, as states? It seems like you need to counter-balance the power of the United States.

Teacher, Quebec

I think there are different reasons why some people in other countries are afraid of Germany. I guess a lot of people are afraid that Germany will get too big. In Europe, Germany will play the largest role, it already does almost, and even more after reunification. It's easy to figure out what that means economically. And therefore the fears are legitimate, in my opinion.

Camera assistant, West Berlin

Rathaus (city hall—16% Republikaner [far-right party] vote)

I do not like the feeling in the country at the present. And it is totally against my beliefs to see an entire nation turn inwards. Suddenly nothing seems to be of any importance if it has not to do with Germany, the opening of the borders or at least the development in Eastern Europe. I do not believe that it is healthy for a people as well as a person to ignore that there is an outside world that is at least as important as their own limited sphere. Germans, as probably most Europeans, have always been rather egotistic, now they are egocentric as well.

Secretary, Aachen

We can't afford to be patriotic anymore because the world has become so small that if you are so concentrated and centered on what is happening in our country or any other country, you are going to miss the entire bigger picture. I just think that we Americans are realizing now that we are not as important as we thought. It was all self-aggrandizement. On an economic level we were considering ourselves number one for a long time. Especially when Reagan pulled us out of the depression by artificially stimulating the economy with billions and billions of dollars that we didn't have. Our trade deficit is enormous and our national deficit is enormous.

College student, New Mexico

Mehringdamm (upscale station)

God, well, in any case, I'm starting to feel it as a Turk, because the East Germans are coming over here and saying, "Look at them, they take away our jobs," and things like that. And they say, "We have a right to live here and you don't because you're not German." We can live here, and we have a right to live here.

Saleswoman, West Berlin

Some Latinos may come to the United States because of economic or political reasons, from Guatemala, Nicaragua, El Salvador. I think their economic crisis is related to the political situation... I think the U.S. has a very partial immigration law. It affects me and other people just because of the way we look. Even though some Latinos were born in this country, there's discrimination. They go for a job and the employer automatically assumes that these people are illegal. So it's like you need to be white and blonde so they don't question you. Once they see you have dark hair, brown eyes, dark skin, they say, "Yeah, maybe this person is not an American citizen."

Carpenter, New York

People have come to realize that a conservative government, I mean freedom, democracy and middle of the road to right-wing can deliver the highest standard of living, and that's the net net. The standard of living is obviously going to be much higher in the developed country, and if you would let people come from the less developed countries to the developed countries, you'd have a complete exodus. You have to have certain controls, you can't let everyone in because everyone would come here. The answer is to export the things that have brought success to this country, which are freedom, free enterprise and individual initiative. And with that model—that's got to be the model—you're going to have a tremendous expansion elsewhere.

Lawyer, New York

People are all people, foreigners are people, too. But I think you have to see it all in the larger picture, of course. How things are in Berlin, the housing crisis and everything, and that's part of it. And in my opinion our own people who live here and who were born here and so on, that they should have their apartment ahead of the refugees. In any case, people who have lived here and were born here and grew up here have a right ahead of those who have just come.

Older man, no further details, West Berlin

Right now, we are not yet free as East German citizens as long as we are somehow considered subjects, that we have an exchange rate of one to one, it doesn't help the work ethic much, everything is a mess because of it. For us freedom is, so to speak, "the free sale," the sellout to the west.

Construction worker, East Berlin

For me personally, freedom means that I am in charge of myself, of my freedom, of my job, and I see this freedom endangered, not just in these regards but in general. Because I feel like the city is bursting at the seams right now, and all this screaming about freedom and reunification is too much for me, I feel so pressured by what the politicians are pushing right now that I mostly feel like getting out of here.

Seamstress, East Berlin

I think that everybody should have the economic capability to live wherever they want, do whatever they want, eat whatever they want. It's not eat whatever they can but eat whatever they want. I don't think America is fulfilling my idea of freedom. I watch on the news and read in the newspaper about what's happening in other countries, in Eastern Europe, and I don't understand what the difference is between what is happening in Hungary and Romania and what is happening in Nicaragua and El Salvador. I think the American government only defends freedom and democracy when it's convenient for them, they can use the word "freedom" however they want.

Waiter, New York

I don't think America's economic power is changing for the worse, I think things are getting better, I'll tell you, things are changing, you have to understand that it's becoming a world economy. Now labor in this country is expensive. And if you don't need a high level of expertise, things will tend to be made in that part of the world where labor is cheapest. And what we do best—we will do. There are things that we can do best. So that's what's happening, it's sorting itself out and I don't think things are getting worse, I think they're getting better and better. Hell, things are better than they've ever been and they're going to get even better.

Businessman, New York

For Asians now, the USA is not the place to come. America is not safe. We used to think that America was a dream. But here and now nobody come out no more. Not safe place. Moneywise, there is not many good jobs left. Too much people coming. Now even the people inside America, they cannot get good jobs, education, they not have that many good opportunities left. Of course, United States is big, but I believe the government needs something to reconstruct the opportunities of the whole country. I think something got lost. And especially in the city, New York City. I don't know what the city should do, all the big companies moved out. People, not only New Yorkers, but in cities all over the country are lost. Big companies like Coca-Cola, IBM they moved out. Only the poor people left. Poor people against poor people, nothing. Vagabonds.

Factory manager, New York

America's power has changed. I don't think they have the ability to affect global events like they used to. There are other nations out there—Germany, for instance, which has a lot more power than it used to ten years ago. Therefore, they want to make decisions for themselves and not toe the line of what America has to say, and they have every right to do that.

Investment banker, New York

Among my friends everybody feels like the new trend is all about Germanness, about being proud again to be German. So much is all being forgotten. For months there's only been one subject, Germany, and I feel like the media has forgotten about everything else. If you look at cover stories, it's always about German this and German that, East Germany, then maybe an article about Nelson Mandela being freed. And in my opinion, it's the same within politics, the whole issue of foreigners is secondary.

Teacher, East Berlin

After 1945, everything was possible. And I'm proud to be German. In '45, I was 15 years old, and I was glad in 1949 to be able to help build a new Germany in our Republic in the sense of the text of our national anthem. I poured my entire energy into it. And the leadership of our country misused the trust of the people, misused it wretchedly, and ruined everything that the people had achieved.

Retired pilot, East Berlin

I don't know what patriotism is, and I don't think I ever really knew. I think the last time we had a patriotic feeling was when Reagan was at his height. And it was a false patriotism. It was this patriotism to an image rather than to the country itself. We can't afford to be patriotic anymore because the world has become so small that if you are so concentrated and centered on what is happening in our country or any other country, you are going to miss the entire bigger picture, which has to do with humanity rather than Americans or Russians or whatever.

Student, New York

People right or wrong felt that they were being abused by liberals or liberal theory. I'm not saying that they were, but I think they are rebelling against it. I think that the person who is taking a police exam and sees that he scores a high enough grade to pass but a black who may have been discriminated against has a lesser score than he does but the black gets the promotion because of his color. I think that has a lot to do with the rebelling against liberalism. Maybe it is because they are trying to correct past wrongs. My perception is that if someone got promoted over me because they were black, I would probably be upset. Conservatism in America has a lot to do with personal economics.

Financial consultant, New York

Some Latinos may come to the United States because of economic or political reasons, from Guatemala, Nicaragua, El Salvador. I think their economic crisis is related to the political situation... I think the U.S. has a very partial immigration law. It affects me and other people just because of the way we look. Even though some Latinos were born in this country, there's discrimination. They go for a job and the employer automatically assumes that these people are illegal. So it's like you need to be white and blonde so they don't question you. Once they see you have dark hair, brown eyes, dark skin, they say, "Yeah, maybe this person is not an American citizen."

Carpenter, New York

It has been my experience when I've talked to people from the conservative corner that they felt they had someone behind them or in front of them and they belonged and felt strong in general. I suppose it isn't so much xenophobia, well, of course, it is to some degree, but the main thing is that you can rely on someone and don't have to do things alone, that you can swim along with the strong crowd.

Student, West Berlin

Well, I don't see how anyone who's seen pictures of World War II could possibly think right-wing, that's my opinion.

Homemaker, West Berlin

Well, in general, I have nothing against foreigners, only they have to adapt to things here, because there are areas where they live, things look a mess. Beer cans lying around and things like that, they just throw things down... it's the same with the little bit of green we have, the kids run around and rip up the little bit of green we have. There isn't anybody who isn't pleased there's a little bit of green around, don't you say so?

Retiree, West Berlin

God, well, in any case, I'm starting to feel it as a Turk, because the East Germans are coming over here and saying, "Look at them, they take away our jobs," and things like that. And they say, "We have a right to live here and you don't because you're not German." We can live here, and we have a right to live here.

Saleswoman, West Berlin

People are immigrating from the less developed countries and the poorer countries where the standards of living are very low... not only to here, they'd immigrate wherever they'd let them. They have come to realize that a conservative government, I mean freedom, democracy and middle-of-the-road to right-wing can deliver the highest standard of living, and that's the net net. The standard of living is obviously going to be much higher in the developed country, and if you would let people come from the less developed countries to the developed countries, you'd have a complete exodus. You have to have certain controls, you can't let everyone in because everyone would come here. The answer is to export the things that have brought success to this country, which are freedom, free enterprise and individual initiative. And with that model—that's got to be the model—you're going to have a tremendous expansion elsewhere.

Lawyer, New York

I'd rather there weren't a future... I think the future of Germany in the foreseeable future isn't separate from its past, and until there has been a real discussion about what kind of a future Germany could have, what Germans are capable of, what they want, what their goals are, until these things are publicly dealt with, I'd rather there weren't any future.

Psychologist, West Berlin

Who knows what we are going to be living in. People get so far removed from political process that they stop caring. People have to become a lot more passionate about what they do and stand up for causes or certain rights that we have now, like abortion, in five years will be gone. If things like abortion are outlawed then what will be next? Freedom of speech, basic rights? People need to get more involved.

Student, New York

I think that the eastern part of the country ought to try to stand on its own feet, not to let itself become too dependent on West Germans. I think West Germans have a very capitalist mindset, but I also think there are signs that consumerism is being curbed a bit, which is just starting to emerge in East Germany. I suppose it's going to get worse, and I hope it doesn't come to the point where we end up raising our children in a totally consumerist Germany.

Student, West Berlin

In general, I think the policy around foreigners is a bit clumsy in some situations, maybe handled insensitively by some politicians, sometimes even crude.

Student, West Berlin

It's quite obvious that there is a reunification in process which is simply going to have a political, economic and social effect. For example, the business bosses in the West see their chance to make even more money.

Student, West Berlin

I hope that the city becomes really colorful again. And that maybe we'll have less unemployment and just enjoy ourselves in Berlin.

Student, West Berlin

Well, everybody wants to fight back against being treated unfairly. And whereas they don't find exactly the best support in other parties, with the Republikaner, he probably feels like they represent his interests, that they listen to him, or that he gets some recognition with his problems.

Schoolboy, West Berlin

I believe that our own people, those who live here and were born here and so on, that they should have their apartments ahead of the refugees.

Older man, no further details, West Berlin

Patriotism is something that separates, it doesn't unite, it means isolation from one's self and therefore from others.

Car salesman, West Berlin

Right now, we are not yet free as East German citizens as long as we are considered subjects, that we have an exchange rate of one to one, it doesn't help the work ethic much, everything is a mess because of it. For us freedom is so to speak of the free sale, the sellout to the west.

Construction worker, East Berlin

There're all different kinds among the Republikaner, and you should differentiate between the ones who are in politics and the ones who run around using their fists.

Construction worker, East Berlin

Freedom, oh, that's a tough one, because a lot of people take freedoms for themselves that they shouldn't have, and lots of others don't have any freedoms where they should have a right to it.

Welfare recipient, West Berlin

I do think that everyone should be a little bit proud of his own culture, but when it turns into nationalism, then it's somehow harmful, isn't it?

Welfare recipient, West Berlin

Germany is powerful, somehow aggressive and is the economic leader in the world and is geared to wanting to have more, which is carried out in an aggressive way, if need be, and I figure things will turn out that way.

Welfare recipient, West Berlin

Above all in government offices, they are pretty rude, at the employment office, at the welfare office. We have so many problems, because we don't know the language very well.

Polish woman, West Berlin

Well, when I can go where I want, travel, I suffered a lot under it, my mother died because I couldn't help her, visit her, and now I could but it's too late. Well, freedom is a great concept.

Retired woman, Berlin

Well, I think it's totally harmless if the two Germanies come together again, what once was won't happen again, and I think that older people who have lived through all that will fight to make sure young people don't do any of that.

Saleswoman, West Berlin

Because everything is coming to a head, where it becomes clear that something is going to change, either it will all collapse, or there's a search for new goals. In order to change something, the easiest way out is to look to the right.

Camera assistant, West Berlin

God, well, in any case, I'm starting to feel it as a Turk, because the East Germans are coming over here and saying, "Look at them, they take away our jobs."

Saleswoman, West Berlin

In any case, I don't mean the freedom to consume, nor necessarily what the people on our side have chosen.

Retired pilot, East Berlin

In the past, some people have already said we ought to put the West German and East German medals together, then you really can see how Germany stands globally...

Retired pilot, East Berlin

An economically strong country and a freed country attracts people who are repressed, who don't have rights in their own countries and hope for economic and cultural gains. The right of asylum has to be continued but we have to protect ourselves from a sellout.

Retired pilot, East Berlin

None of our neighbors should need to fear Germany.

Retired pilot, East Berlin

I think there is a basis on which a certain nationalism could develop again, but I think that this is a general tendency throughout Europe right now.

Sculptor, Amsterdam

This being swallowed totally, this wanting to be united no matter what, this patriotic feeling is not for me, because this whole being hugged to death is a little bit too much for me.

Fashion designer, East Berlin

Towards foreigners, well I don't know, I don't watch much politics, like on television... I don't really know exactly.

Schoolgirl, West Berlin

The only thing I'm afraid of is that they might get the bright idea to make us leave, to throw us Turks out for no reason.

Schoolboy, West Berlin

Well, I don't see how anyone who's seen pictures of World War II could possibly think right-wing, that's my opinion.

Homemaker, West Berlin

I don't think it's important which country you are a citizen of, so I wouldn't say that the Germans should get the jobs, or whoever has a particular color of eyes or something, in my opinion whoever wants to be a German should be free to do so.

Student, West Berlin

Simply because they are a large group and I suppose that people feel stronger in large groups, and it has been my experience when I've talked to people from the conservative corner that they felt they had someone behind them or in front of them, they belonged and felt strong in general.

Student, West Berlin

I think West Germans have a very capitalist mindset, but I also think there are signs that consumerism is being curbed a bit, which is just starting to emerge in East Germany. I suppose it's going to get worse, and I hope it doesn't come to the point where we end up raising our children in a totally consumerist Germany.

Student, West Berlin

Freedom has to be won, it isn't given.

Psychologist, West Berlin

It's just that mentality of bigger, higher, faster, further, that we aren't able to change, that we only think bigger, higher, faster, further, and that we don't have values.

Psychologist, West Berlin

The city is bursting at the seams right now, and all this screaming about freedom and reunification is too much for me. I feel so pressured by what the politicians are pushing right now that I mostly feel like getting out of here.

Seamstress, East Berlin

It doesn't mean for me that I have to be ashamed in any way, but have to be conscious of my history, of recent history and, specifically with regards to foreigners.

Seamstress, East Berlin

So much is all being forgotten. For months there's only been one subject, Germany, and I feel like the media has forgotten about everything else.

Teacher, East Berlin

Well, the way all of this is going, we just have to wait and see what happens, but I am really pleased in general with how things have gone, the way people have gone out into the streets and really struggled for freedom.

Healer, West Berlin

The ego of most West Germans is based on their economic situation and the fact that probably in no other country in the world do simple folk live so well.

Taxi driver, Kassel

I think that everybody should have the economic capability to live wherever they want, do whatever they want, eat whatever they want. It's not eat whatever they can but eat whatever they want. It shouldn't be a question of if you can afford it.

Waiter, New York

I think the American government only defends freedom and democracy when it's convenient for them, they can use the word "freedom" however they want.

Waiter, New York

Freedom is being able to express what you feel sexually and not being jailed for it or being persecuted for it.

Assistant buyer, New York

I'm just very angry at the government for not funding enough for AIDS research and things like that. They just don't want to think about it, they'd rather spend their money on their guns.

Assistant buyer, New York

People have come to realize that a conservative government, I mean freedom, democracy and middle-of-the-road to right-wing can deliver the highest standard of living, and that's the net net.

Lawyer, New York

I don't think that there's anybody homeless who doesn't choose to be homeless, and there's anybody not working who doesn't choose to be not working.

Lawyer, New York

We're absorbing two or three million illegal aliens every year and if you add to the jobs that are being created by this very vital free economy that we have, I think there's a tremendous boom on frankly.

Lawyer, New York

Down beneath it all I think Americans love this country and will fight and die for it anytime, even for other people's freedom, as we have in Vietnam, Korea.

Lawyer, New York

You have to have certain controls, you can't let everyone in because everyone would come here.

Lawyer, New York

The answer is to export the things that have brought success to this country, which are freedom, free enterprise, and individual initiative.

Lawyer, New York

Of course, United States is big, but I believe the government needs something to reconstruct the opportunities of the whole country. I think something got lost.

Factory manager, New York

There is a lot America could do in its own country, but America's hand reaches out so far into other territories that we don't even belong in that America's own people suffer because of it.

Traffic cop, New York

As long as everybody is locked in a power struggle to be first in line, there is never really going to be freedom.

Traffic cop, New York

I personally feel that in the United States we are now looking at other countries that are much more successful than us, such as Japan and Germany. We are falling further and further behind as far as our financial situation and our debt situation.

Homemaker, New York

I don't think people really care what America's impact on the global thing is. And basically people are apathetic. They don't care and they don't take the time to inform themselves about what is going on.

Investment banker, New York

People right or wrong felt that they were being abused by liberals or liberal theory. I'm not saying that they were, but I think they are rebelling against that.

Financial consultant, New York

Conservatism in America has a lot to do with personal economics.

Financial consultant, New York

The wealthier sections might be more patriotic because they have more reason to believe in capitalism than any other group.

Student, New York

Being American means we don't have to think about what it means to be American because we have all the freedom and choices.

Student, New York

Americans get so far removed from the political process that they stop caring. They get involved with their BMWs and don't take anything else into consideration. It is ultimately all economically based.

Student, New York

It scares me to think about having a family and what kind of world I'm going to be bringing a family into. And if I'm going to have to be one of those people closing my eyes to get by.

Student, New York

I think the last time we had a patriotic feeling was when Reagan was at his height. And it was a false patriotism. It was this patriotism to an image rather than to the country itself.

Student, New York

We can't afford to be patriotic anymore because the world has become so small that if you are so concentrated and centered on what is happening in our country or any other country, you are going to miss the entire bigger picture.

Student, New York

I just think that we Americans are realizing now that we are not as important as we thought. It was all self-aggrandizement.

College student, New Mexico